

General Knowledge

Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Buddhism-II



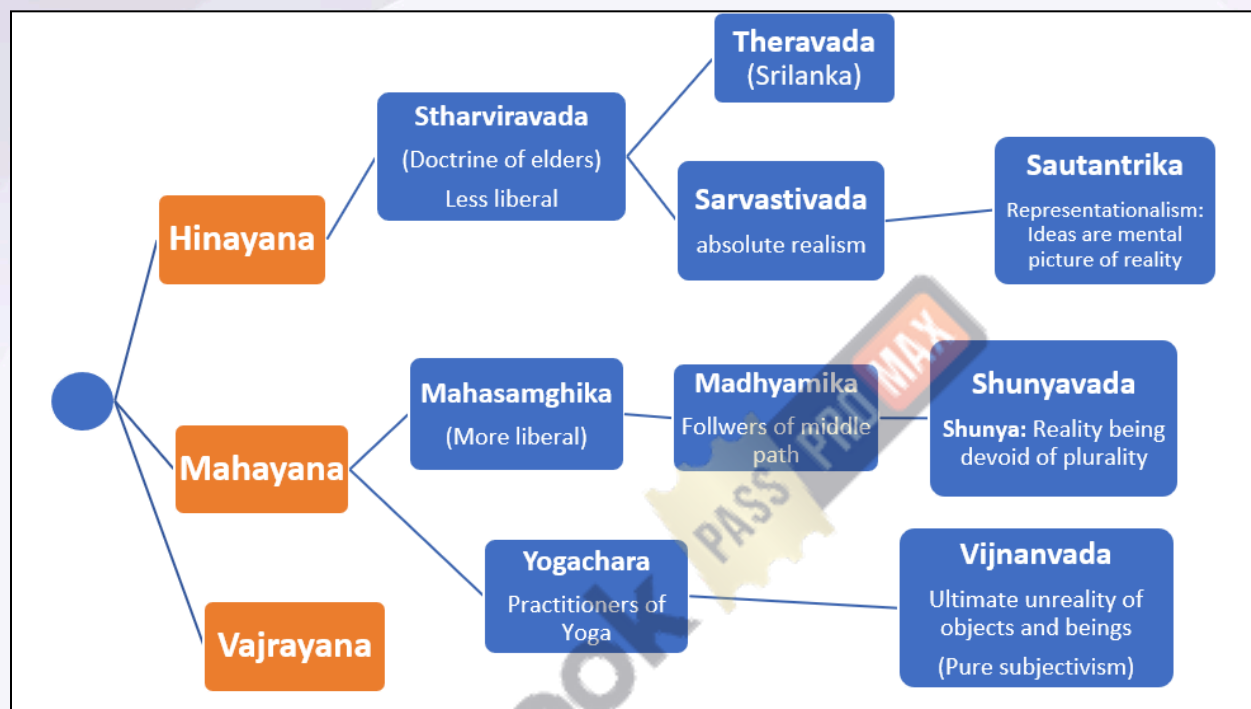
BUDDHISM-II

Literary Contributions of Buddhism

- **Tripitaka (The Three Baskets):**
 - **Buddhism's religious literature** is collectively known as the **Tripitaka**:
 - **Vinaya Pitaka**: Discusses the **rules of discipline** for monks and nuns.
 - **Sutta Pitaka**: Contains **sermons** and stories of **Buddha**.
 - **Abhidhamma Pitaka**: Deals with **philosophical** and **metaphysical** discussions.
- **Famous Buddhist Texts:**
 - **Dighnikaya, Nirgrantha, Jataka tales, Terigatha,** and **Ashvaghosha's Buddhacharitra** are key Buddhist texts that contributed to the spread and understanding of **Buddhism**.
- **Development of Universities:**
 - **Buddhist monasteries** became centres of learning, leading to the development of prominent educational institutes like **Nalanda, Taxila, Valabhi,** and **Vikramasila**.



Different Schools of Buddhism



Hinayana School (Theravada)

- **Meaning:** 'The Lesser Path', with Theravada translating to 'Doctrine of the Elders', follows the original teachings of **Buddha**.
- It views Buddha as a **human** and discourages **idol worship**, focusing instead on **self-discipline** and **meditation** to attain **individual salvation**.
- Scriptures are in **Pali**, and the **ultimate goal** is **Nirvana**, with practices currently found in **Sri Lanka**, **Myanmar**, and **Thailand**.
- **Ashoka** was a significant patron of this school.

Mahayana School

- **Meaning:** ‘The Greater Path’, it originated later than Hinayana and is considered a heterodox school.
- **Buddha** is treated as a **divine figure**, with **idol worship** of **Buddha** and **Bodhisattvas**, and the belief in **universal liberation** for all beings through **spiritual upliftment**.
- Its scriptures are in **Sanskrit**, it emphasizes **mantras**, and it is currently practised in **Japan** and **China**.
- **Kanishka** was a notable patron of this school.

Vajrayana School

- **Meaning:** ‘Vehicle of the Thunderbolt’, Vajrayana is also known as **Tantric Buddhism**, emphasizing the **Two Truths Doctrine** (Conventional and Ultimate truths).
- It uses symbolic language, known as **Sandhya-base**, and worships fierce deities like **Tara**, with an emphasis on the **Guru (Lama)**.
- Popular in **Tibet**, **Nepal**, **Bhutan**, and **Mongolia**, it arose in **Bengal** and **Bihar**, gaining prominence in the **11th century**.

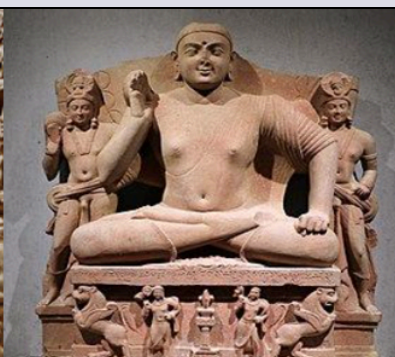
Art and Architecture Contributions of Buddhism

Buddhism significantly contributed to **Indian art** and **architecture**, influencing styles that persisted for centuries. Some major developments include:

- **Gandhara, Mathura, and Amaravati Styles:**
 - **Gandhara art:** Influenced by **Greco-Roman** styles, famous for **sculptures of Buddha** in a **realistic manner**.
 - **Mathura art:** Indigenous Indian style that focused on **Buddha images** and **yakshas**.
 - **Amaravati School:** Known for **delicate carvings** and **narrative sculptures**.



Gandhara Art

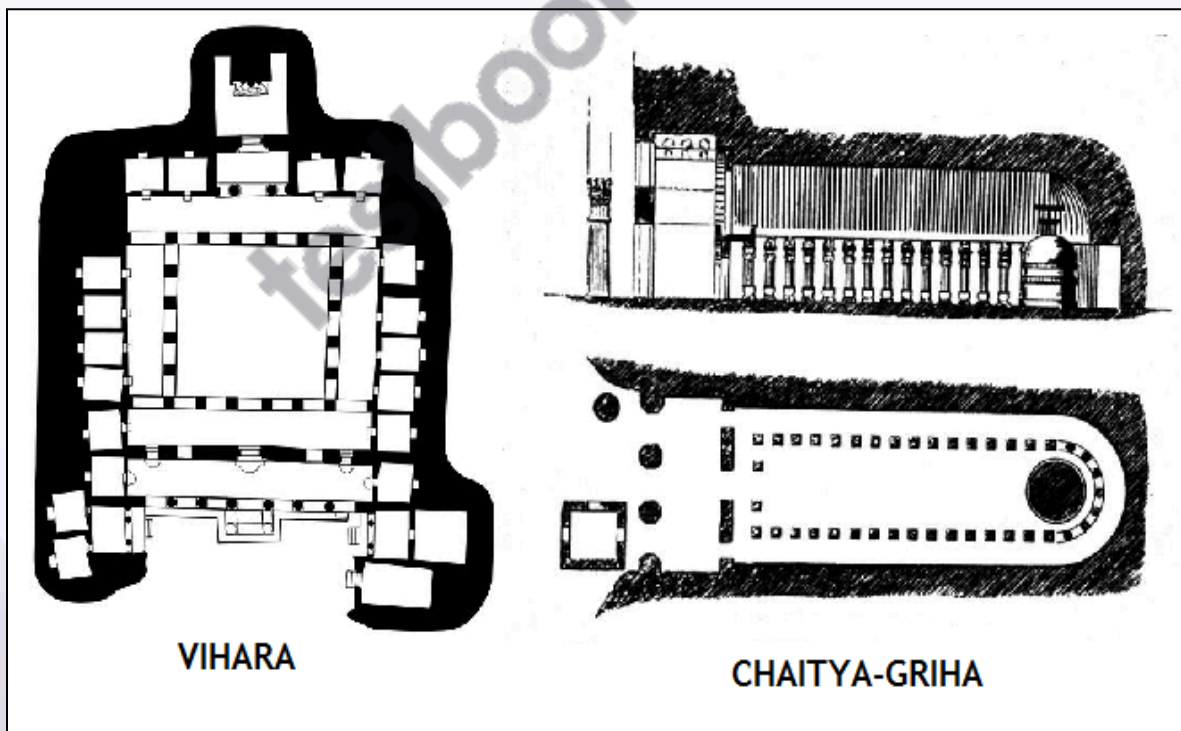


Mathura Art



Amravati School of Art

- **Stupas:**
 - Structures built to house **relics of Buddha**. The most famous stupas include **Sanchi Stupa** and **Bharhut Stupa**.
- **Chaityas and Viharas:**
 - **Chaityas** were prayer halls, and **Viharas** were monasteries where monks resided. Both played a central role in **Buddhist religious life**.
 - Notable examples include the **Ajanta** and **Ellora caves**, which are known for their **rock-cut architecture**.

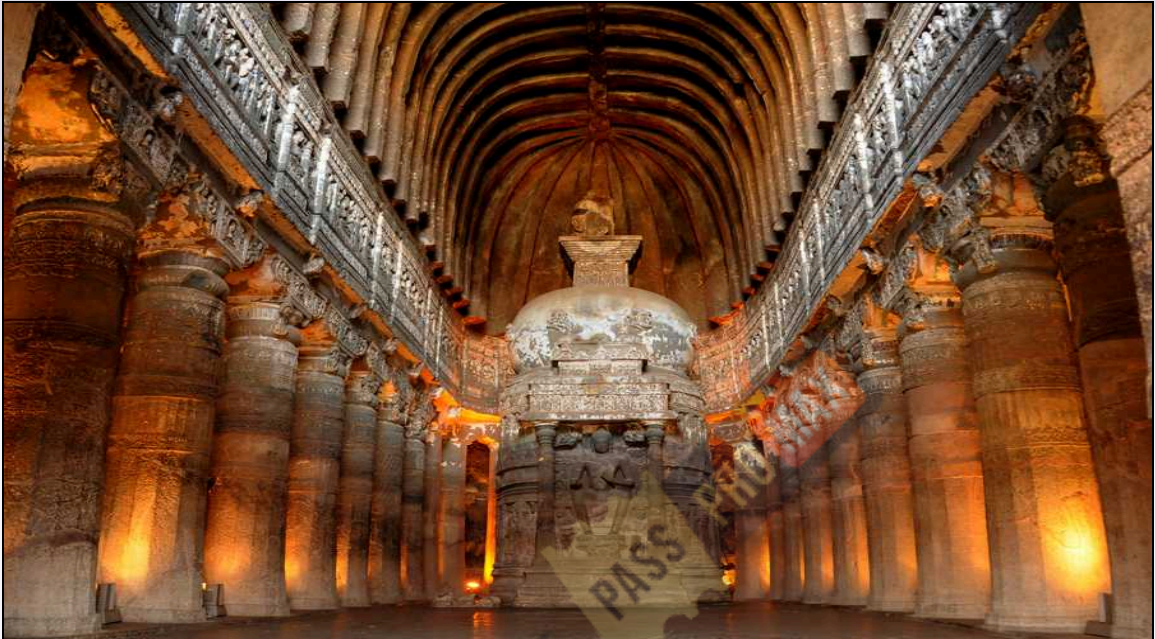


VIHARA

CHAITYA-GRIHA

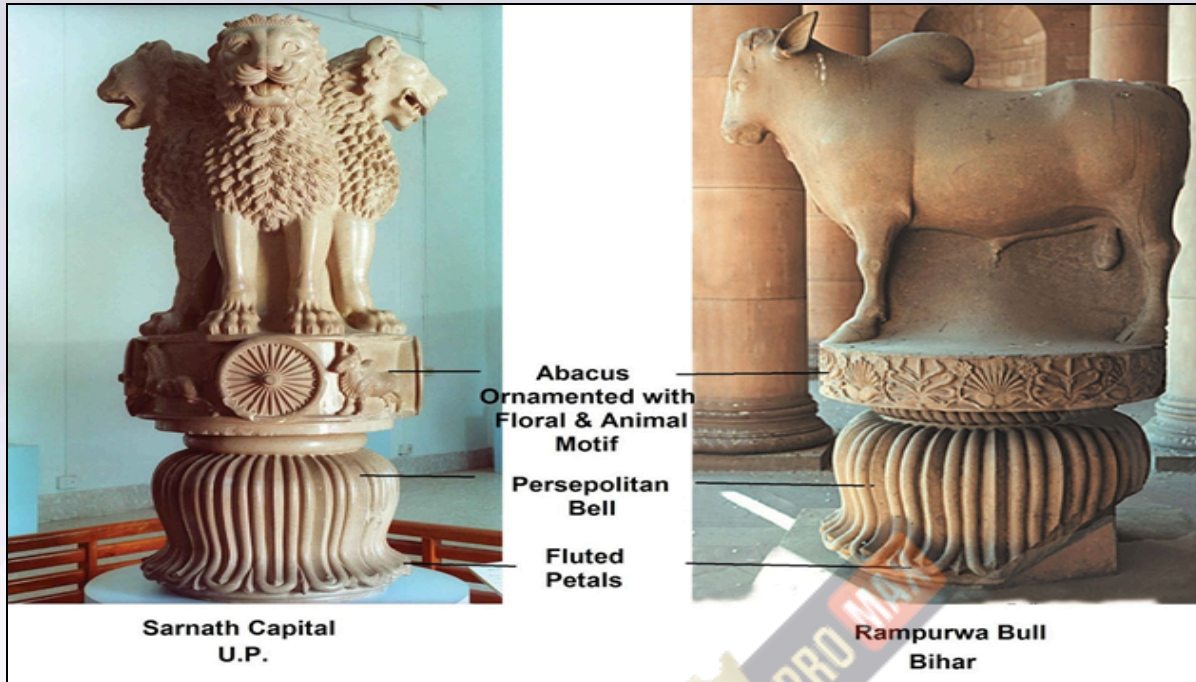
- **Rock-Cut Caves:**

- Caves such as **Ajanta**, **Ellora**, and **Bhaja** were adorned with **Buddhist murals** and **sculptures**. These caves served as **monasteries** and **places of worship** for monks.



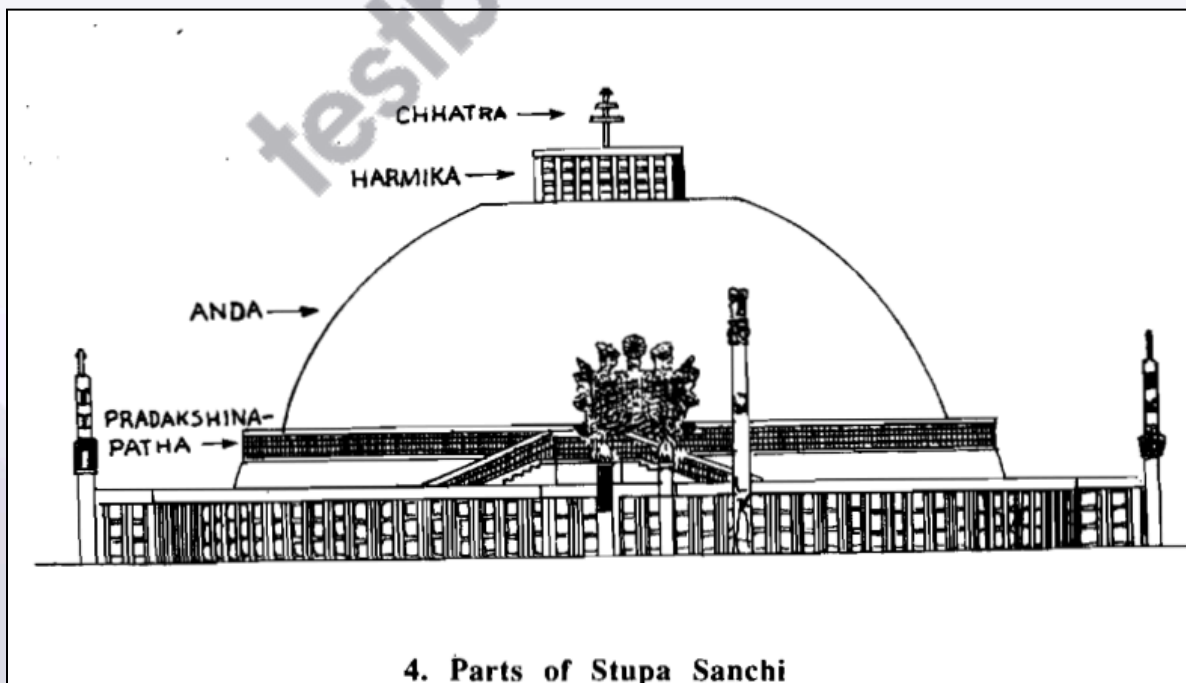
Ellora Caves

- **Pillars and Edicts:**
 - The **Sarnath Pillar**, erected by **Emperor Ashoka**, is a fine example of **Buddhist architecture**. The **lion capital** atop the pillar is now the **national emblem of India**.
- **Yaksha and Yakshi Sculptures:**
 - **Buddhist art** includes depictions of **Yakshas** (male earth spirits) and **Yakshis** (female fertility spirits), found at sites like **Sanchi**.



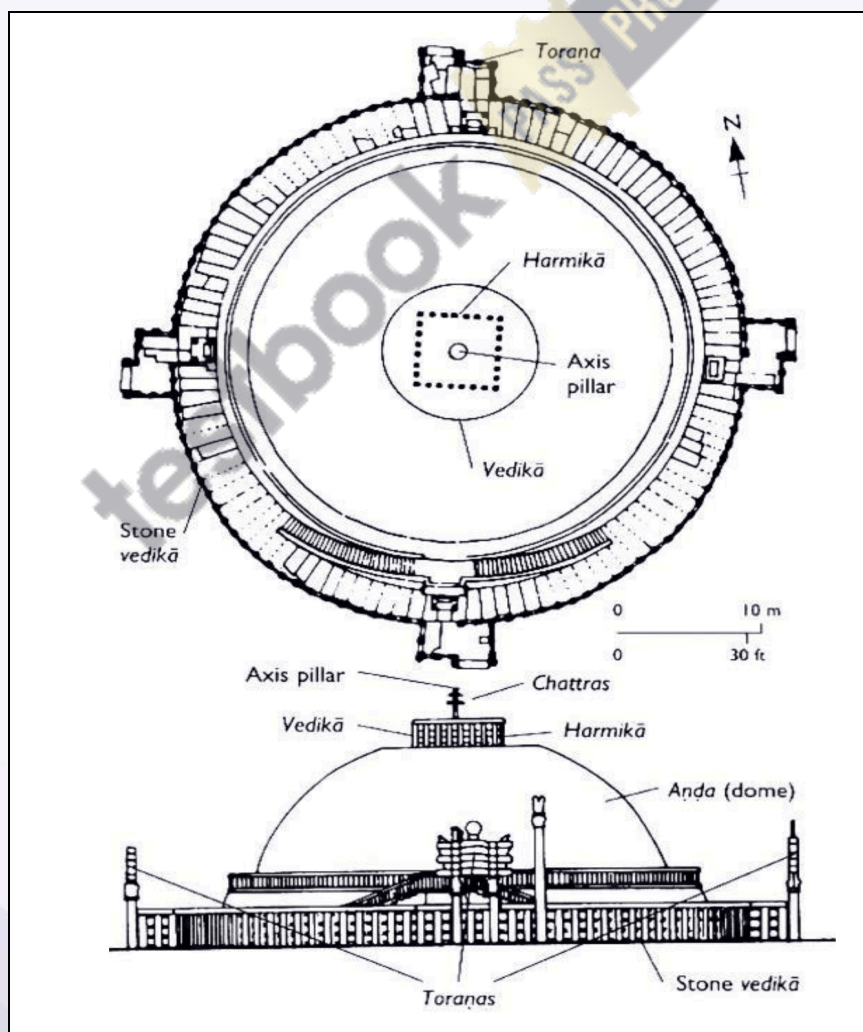
- **Royal Patrons:**
 - **Ashoka, Kanishka, Satavahanas, Rashtrakutas, and Chalukyas** played crucial roles in spreading **Buddhism** and supporting its architectural projects.

Stupas in Buddhism

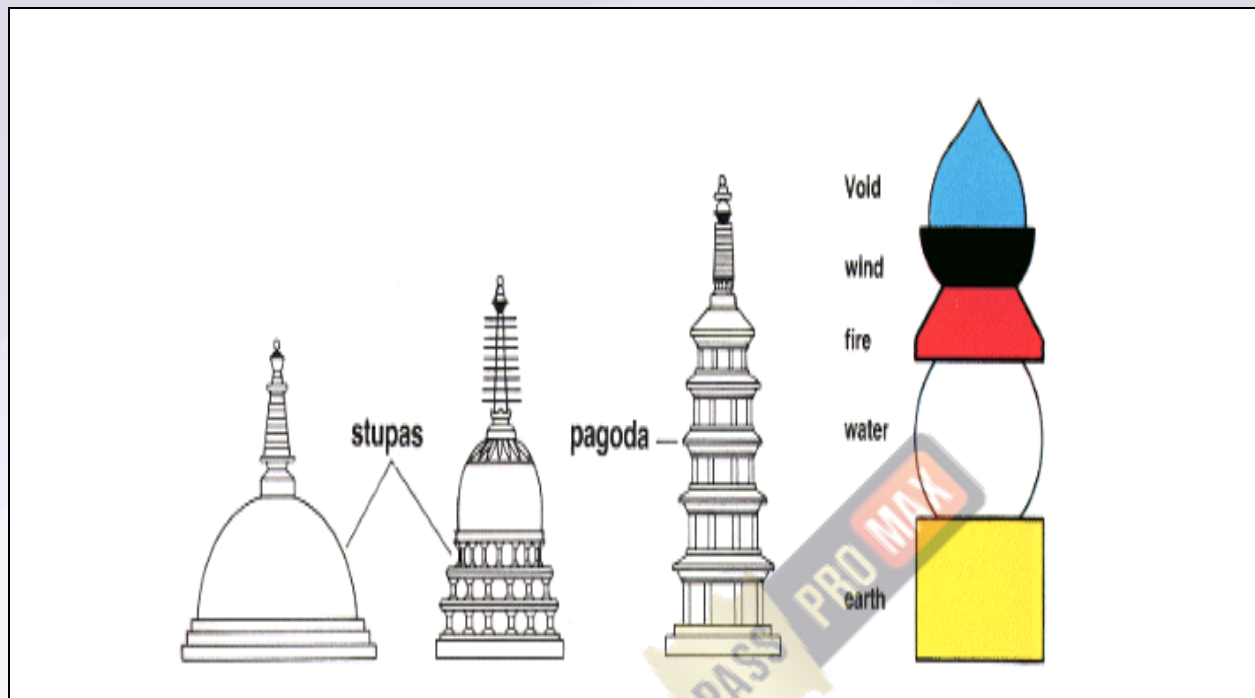


Definition and Purpose:

- **Stupas** are **hemispherical structures** that serve as **Buddhist shrines**, primarily meant to house **relics** of the **Buddha** or other significant figures in Buddhism.
- They symbolize the **enlightened mind** of the Buddha and are often associated with **meditation** and **spiritual growth**.
- **Origin:**
- The tradition of building **stupas** originated in **India**, evolving from burial mounds and relics' repositories in the **6th century BCE**.
- **Emperor Ashoka** played a significant role in popularizing **stupa construction** by erecting **84,000 stupas** to enshrine the Buddha's relics across his empire after the **3rd Buddhist Council**.



Structure and Symbolism:



- The **structure of a stupa** consists of five elements, each symbolizing an aspect of nature:
 - **Base** (Square) – Symbolizes **Earth**.
 - **Dome** (Hemispherical) – Represents **Water**.
 - **Harmika** (Small Square Platform) – Symbolizes **Fire**.
 - **Yasti** (Central Pole) – Represents **Air**.
 - **Chatras** (Umbrella or Spire) – Signifies **Space or Void**.
- The **stupa's spire** also represents the **path to enlightenment**, guiding one through **Dharma** and **spiritual knowledge**.

Types of Stupas:

- **Relic Stupas:** Built to enshrine the **relics** of Buddha or his disciples.
- **Object Stupas:** Contain **sacred objects** representing **Buddhist teachings**.
- **Commemorative Stupas:** Built to commemorate **important events** in Buddha's life.

- **Symbolic Stupas:** Represent **aspects of Buddhist theology**, such as **enlightenment**.
- **Votive Stupas:** Erected by **devotees** as a sign of **devotion** or to mark a significant **pilgrimage**.

Famous Stupas in Buddhism:

- **Sanchi Stupa** (Madhya Pradesh, India): One of the oldest and most important stupas, built by **Ashoka**. It contains **relics** of the **Buddha** and features intricate **carvings** depicting **Buddhist events**.
- **Boudhanath Stupa** (Kathmandu, Nepal): One of the largest stupas in the world, it is a significant site for **Tibetan Buddhism**.
- **Shwedagon Stupa** (Yangon, Myanmar): Considered the most sacred **Buddhist pagoda** in **Myanmar**, enshrining relics of **four Buddhas**.
- **Mahabodhi Stupa** (Bodhgaya, India): Built at the site where Buddha attained **enlightenment**, this stupa holds immense significance for **Buddhists worldwide**.

Spread of Stupa Architecture:

- As Buddhism spread, the architecture of stupas evolved across different regions, leading to variations in design:
 - In **Sri Lanka**, stupas, called **dagobas**, became central to **monasteries**.
 - In **Tibet**, stupas are called **chortens** and have distinct **multi-tiered structures**.
 - In **East Asia**, stupas transformed into **pagodas**, characterized by **tall, tiered towers** that are common in **China** and **Japan**.

UNESCO Heritage Sites Related to Buddhism

- These sites are of paramount significance in the history of **Buddhism** and represent critical stages in the evolution of **Buddhist architecture, culture, and religious practices**.

Heritage Site	Location	Explanation	Image
Archaeological Site of Nalanda Mahavihara	Nalanda, Bihar	Nalanda was a prominent center for Buddhist studies, attracting scholars from all over the world. Established in the 5th century CE. The site was declared a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2016.	
Buddhist Monuments at Sanchi	Madhya Pradesh	Sanchi Stupa was originally commissioned by Emperor Ashoka in the 3rd century BCE. The monument is an important site for Buddhist pilgrimage and symbolizes Buddha's enlightenment and teachings. The site was inscribed on the UNESCO list in 1989.	

Mahabodhi Temple Complex at Bodh Gaya	Bihar	Bodh Gaya is the place where Siddhartha Gautama attained enlightenment under the Bodhi Tree and became the Buddha. It was declared a World Heritage Site in 2002.	
Ajanta Caves	Aurangabad, Maharashtra	The Ajanta Caves are renowned for their beautiful rock-cut cave temples and intricate Buddhist paintings and sculptures. The caves date back to around the 2nd century BCE. The site was declared a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1983.	